matter of fact, in an editorial in a leading newspaper the next day it was said, 'The Prime Minister's Office has distanced itself from the move as the committee has exceeded its terms of reference, and by raising these questions is actually belittling the secular character of the Indian military. Army Chief General J.J. Singh is absolutely correct in expressing a certain reluctance to tabulate religion based data, with the armed forces taking great pride in their ability to keep their heads far above communal waters. He could not be more precise and Justice Sachar must draw a lesson from the spirit of the Army Chief's remarks.'[1] Similar views were expressed by many other national dailies too. The government accepted our viewpoint, and the matter was not raised thereafter.

Having a roof over the head is the cherished dream of all officers, JCOs and men. The fact that most of the beneficiaries of the Army Welfare Housing Organization (AWHO) projects have been officers and JCOs, made me wonder if that was our objective in starting AWHO in December 1978. What about the 'jawans' or soldiers? They could apply for a home only if it was affordable. The homes we were making were simply out of reach of the other ranks. Hence I conceived of a low-cost housing scheme dedicated to serving and retired soldiers. We tried out this concept at the Maratha Light Infantry Regimental Centre, where a sample dwelling unit was constructed using locally available material. I was amazed to see that a one bedroom, sitting room and kitchen unit with all fittings for lights, fans and Indian-style toilet, cost about one-and-a-half-lakh rupees to construct. This did not include the cost of the land. This is how the 'Jai Jawan Awas Yojana' scheme came about and has become very popular. During my tenure as the chief, the first project located in the city of Jaipur was finished in less than two years, on a fast-track basis. Flats were allotted by a computerized draw, and handed over in August 2007 to soldiers at around Rs 6 lakhs; the going market price of such flats was three to four times more. Besides, they were given loans at concessional interest rates, which were lower than bank rates, from the Army Group Insurance Fund. Encouraged by the response, I asked the managing director of AWHO to carry out a survey of other locations where the soldiers